

Snowden spent his time in Hong Kong reading books, ordering room service, and rarely leaving the hotel.

On May 20, Snowden boarded a plane bound for Hong Kong. He carried encrypted flash drives containing thousands of top-secret NSA documents. Even though China had a reputation for suppressing personal freedoms, Snowden chose Hong Kong because the region had a tradition of allowing free speech. He also thought US intelligence agents would have a harder time operating in China, a country with complicated ties to the United States. He hoped this would make it more difficult to deport him. Though he used his own name and credit cards—not wanting to appear as if he were undercover and draw attention to himself—Snowden stayed in his room at the Mira hotel.

A Plan

From his hotel room, Snowden also continued his encrypted chats with his media partners Poitras and

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